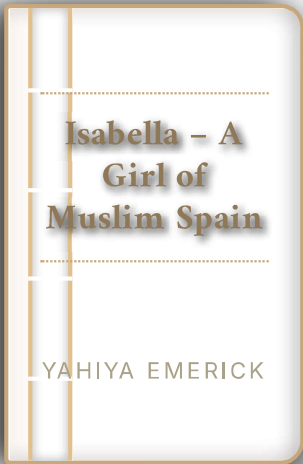




Isabella – A Girl of ...

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Ch 1: In a Luscious Garden

In a famous garden of Spain, well known for its beauty and freshness vying with the garden of Eden, which was always crowded by sight-seers, two learned men were engaged in a theological discussion in a corner. The sun at this time had completed its round and was preparing to set in the west; while the enchanting songs of birds returning to nests were exhilarating the passers-by. A Christian girl, whose name is given in history as Isabella, was also sitting with some friends in the garden and watching with delight the beauty of Nature. Aged about sixteen or seventeen she was the daughter of a Christian priest. In her "beauty and grace she looked like a hourie of Paradise, and nobles and religious leaders aspired for her hand to make their lives happy and joyful, but her father wanted her to be the model of virgin Mary and did not want to give her away in marriage. Since she was being given religious training, she was well acquainted with religious matters and took keen interest in theological discussions. [1]

In a bed of roses, in a corner, as stated above, sat some Muslims, who appeared to be men of learning, engaged in some discussion. [2]

First man: Saint Paul has written in one of his letters[Epistle to the Galatians, 3 : 10] that religious law is a curse and Jesus Christ came to relieve us from that curse. What after all does this mean? [3]

Second man (laughing): You want to understand it from me, although even Christian priests... [4]

Isabella, who was sitting at a little distance with her girl friends was alerted on the words "even Christian priests" and said to one of her friends: These Muslims seem to

be talking about our religion. Let us hear quietly what they say. A friend responded: Since these Muslims have come here our religion is in great danger. [5]

Isabella: Stop talking. Keep quiet and let us hear what they say. [6]

First man: Muaz! You have said that even Christian priests do not understand it. Do you mean to say that they are following Christianity without understanding it? [7]

Second man: Umar Lahmi! Just put this question to some eminent priest and see what he says. But first you' should tell me your Objection to what Saint Paul has said. [8]

Umar Lahmi: There is no objection in fact. I Just want to understand it and since you have often talked to Christians and have also read their literature, so I want to understand it from you. What I want to know is that when religious law is a curse and Prophet Jesus came to relieve the Christians from this curse, therefore, theft, fornication, disobedience to parents will also be permissible although no Christian believes in their permissibility. [9]

Muaz: How are theft and fornication and other such sins related to the religious law being a curse? I cannot quite follow you. [10]

Umar Lahmi: What I mean is that the Old Testament is the religious law which enjoins that. One should not steal, should not fornicate, should not give trouble to his neighbour, should not disobey his parents, etc. But when the entire religious law is a curse, it will also be a curse to obey these injunctions as these injunctions are also religious law and the very core of it. If what Saint Paul says is correct, then Christians should also steal, fornicate and commit such other sins. But like us they follow this

religious law, then they are accursed and Christians who object to these sins are condemned as they object to obedience of religious law. [11]

Muaz : Funny, you want me to clear the very objection which I have put to Christians so often. [12]

Umar Lahmi: Have you ever put it to Christians? What was their reply? [13]

Muaz: They tried to explain it away and were perplexed. [14]

Just then there was the call for the Maghrib prayer and the two learned men made their ablution in a nearby tank and offered prayer [15]

Isabella had listened to this conversation very attentively being keenly interested in theological questions and felt the weight of the objection. She put her mind to it and tried to find out an explanation that she might put it to Muaz and Umar Lahmi. But despite all efforts she was unable to find a solution and, still absorbed in the question, she got up along with her friends thinking that she would ask her father about it. [16]

Isabella left her companions at a crossroad and walked to the eastern gate of Cordova. [17]



First Steps You've started your first chapter!